He claimed that both countries should be paying more to offset the costs of basing US forces in their countries and intimated he might consider walking away from the alliances if Tokyo and Seoul did not contribute more funds. Even more shockingly, he suggested that he might encourage both countries to develop their own nuclear capabilities in response to North Korea. This threatened to undermine the long-standing US nuclear guarantee of so-called extended deterrence, by which Washington promised to defend both Japan and South Korea from nuclear attack in exchange for both countries forgoing an indigenous nuclear deterrent.[36] Trump's surprising electoral victory, then, portended a potentially significant revision of US strategy in Asia, in part by reducing US commitments and confronting China. His unprecedented phone conversation with Taiwan's president, Tsai Ing-wen, during the transition period, further reinforced beliefs that he would not play by the traditional rules of diplomacy.

Once in office, however, the Trump administration adopted a more recognizable approach of reaffirming alliance relationships and engaging with China. Confounding critics who assumed he would pay little attention to the Indo-Pacific, Trump in reality made Asia a centerpiece of his foreign policy, stating that America's goal was a "free and open" Indo-Pacific region (indeed, the Trump administration formally changed the government-employed nomenclature to "Indo-Pacific"). He emphasized his personal relationships in early meetings with Japanese prime minister Shinzo Abe and Chinese president Xi Jinping, but Trump's diplomacy for the most part hewed to traditional discussions over deeper engagement. In addition, Trump attended the major gatherings of international and Pacific leaders and made repeated visits to the area, including the longest presidential trip to the region in decades.

If the Trump administration adopted a specific strategy for US Asia policy, it was to use US pressure to resolve seemingly intractable security and economic problems, while quietly retiring the concept of the overhyped "pivot" to Asia. In two specific ways, Trump departed from the policy of his predecessors. First, following outgoing president Barack Obama's warning that his greatest foreign policy challenge